THE SHE LIST UNDER 50

THE **PROFESSIONALS**

The New Top Gun

WHAT MAKES HER A SHERO

From being part of India's first batch of women fighter pilots to becoming the first woman to complete IAF's elite Fighter Combat Leader course, Bhawana Kanth has several historic firsts to her name

In the first week of August, Squadron Leader Bhawana Kanth added another first to a career already woven into the history of the Indian Air Force (IAF). By completing the elite Fighter Combat Leader (FCL) course at the Tactics and Air Combat Development Establishment, Gwalior, she became the force's first woman 'Top Gun' combat pilot. The demanding course prepares experienced fighter pilots for complex air combat missions, advanced tactical operations, mission planning, tactical decision-making and combat leadership.

SQN LDR BHAWANA KANTH, 33
Fighter pilot, Indian Air Force

Born in Bihar's Darbhanga district in 1992, Bhawana followed in the footsteps of her father, an engineer with Indian Oil Corporation, and earned a Bachelor of Engineering degree in Medical Electronics in 2014. She briefly worked at Tata Consultancy Services, but flying remained her ambition. Clearing the Air Force Common Admission Test, she chose military aviation over a conventional engineering career.

Commissioned into the IAF in June 2016 as part of India's historic first batch of women fighter pilots, alongside Squadron Leaders Avani Chaturvedi and Mohana Singh, she progressed through training on the Kiran and Hawk jet trainers before entering the MiG-21 Bison fighter stream.

In March 2018, she flew her first solo sortie on the Bison. A year later, she became the first Indian woman fighter pilot qualified to undertake combat missions on a fighter aircraft. Her milestones beyond the cockpit continued with the Nari Shakti Puraskar, received alongside Avani and Mohana from President Ram Nath Kovind in 2020, and with representing the IAF tableau in the Republic Day parade in 2021, becoming the first woman fighter pilot to do so.

As her colleagues say, she was not being trained simply to become a fighter pilot; she was being trained to become a combat leader. ■

—Pradip R. Sagar

HER TAKE

"Anything is unconventional only till it becomes the norm. Someone has to be willing first. Sometimes, all it takes is to never give up on your dreams"